The Aging Parent Financial Organization Checklist

What to list, gather and ask Mom about while there's no rush.

Mom runs her own finances, and nothing about that needs to change. This is a list of what's worth writing down, finding and asking her about, a little at a time and with her say-so. Check what you've done. Anything unchecked is something to get to when it suits you both, not a verdict about Mom or about you.

List

- [ ] Every source of income: Social Security, any pension, and anything else that comes in regularly.
- [ ] Checking and savings accounts and any CDs, with the bank or credit union each one is with.
- [ ] Investment, brokerage and retirement accounts, and the company that holds each.
- [ ] Insurance: life insurance, annuities, long-term care insurance, and her health coverage.
- [ ] Property: her home, any other real estate, vehicles, and any business interest.
- [ ] Debts and regular monthly expenses, including anything she already pays for help, if she does.

Gather

- [ ] A recent statement for each account. [1]
- [ ] Her insurance policies, and the deed and other records for any property. [1]
- [ ] Her recent tax returns. [1]
- [ ] One secure place to keep all of it, chosen with Mom: a file, a desk drawer or a notebook. [2]

Ask Mom about

- [ ] Whether she's willing to do this together, and what she'd rather keep to herself.
- [ ] Who looks after her bills and accounts now, and whether anyone helps.
- [ ] Whose name each account and property is in, and who is named as beneficiary. Write down what she says and what the paperwork shows, and change nothing.
- [ ] How she'd like passwords and online access handled, and who she wants to know where the file is kept.

What this checklist doesn't do

It helps you list, gather and ask. It doesn't say which of these matter for Medicaid planning, what any of them adds up to, or whether anything should change. Rules vary by state, so those questions go to your Medicaid planner or the appropriate licensed professional. Nothing here is legal, financial or tax advice.

Ready for the next step?

You've seen what there is to list, gather and ask Mom about, category by category. The planning interview asks about your family's situation and gives you a free planning report you can bring to any conversation about paying for care.

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WHERE THIS COMES FROM

Items marked 1 follow AARP's list of records to find and keep in one place. The item marked 2 follows the National Institute on Aging's checklist. The rest come from the Medicaid Planning Roadmap's own working list for this step.

1. AARP, 5 Steps to Organize Your Loved One's Financial Records
2. National Institute on Aging (NIH), Getting Your Affairs in Order Checklist: Documents to Prepare for the Future